

Conditioning in cheer and in life

Who am I? What made “Aerial” be like the Aerial everyone seemed to know? At first as a little girl I was always quiet, the good kid, the one who raised her hand to speak in and out of scholarly areas. But since joining cheer as a little girl, it definitely made me who I am today. I joined cheer as a freshmen, open to speaking to the older cheer girls I’ve grown to know during the lunches we shared throughout the year. I was always flexible and petite so many of the eldest on the team saw me as their little sister. I loved dancing, cheering and expressing my emotions through my body. However, in my first year of high school cheer, I didn’t feel confident in my performances. But once I was with my team, I was so energized and happy during just practices, but when it got to us having less than 3 minutes to perform I was always nervous. But I stayed, I never had the urge to give up. Why?

The team felt like a sisterhood. There was drama, there was fun, but then came times when we had to come together and actually focus on our skills; all through communication and guidance with each other. Those same girls I see as my older sisters were the same girls who saw me cry and break myself down before every performance. I was there in tears, while they were right by my side telling me “you’re beautiful don’t talk about yourself that way”. They were the ones’ who built me up. They started building me without even realizing it.

Soon I began hearing more compliments “You did so good I seen you at the pep rally Aerial!” My own friends started complimenting me on how good I did in my performances. Even people I didn’t know began to notice how much I improved after each performance. I loved the praise, and I loved knowing that some people were watching me perform when I was used to the opposite. I felt seen, so I started working harder. I decided to start a change in myself, I started stretching everyday and became more flexible with my kicks. I found my cheer voice to become louder. I studied and made cheers, learned cheers, and began helping with cheers. I wasn’t that

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little insecure cheerleader any more. I started building muscle and became toned, and deeply rooted in my cheers. “Oh look, it's Aerial, she's on the cheer team!” I’ve gained the confidence I’ve never had for myself.

“You are now our co-captain Aerial” wow, Junior me? I was just hating looking at myself and thought I had nothing, but throughout my freshmen and sophomore year I built that foundation in me to make it this far. Now I'm co-captain, I'm more open with communicating about how I feel about what we need to fix and how we need to fix it. “Wrong leg! make sure you start off with your right leg!” I would yell as my team was running through our cheers. I was helping the girls younger than me become the best of themselves. I was now the “Older sister”! Whenever we went to games, no matter how tired we were or how frustrated I was as a captain wanting better for my team, I would still communicate and push them forward.

Now it's ‘comp’ season, our very first year of being in any cheerleading competition ever for our high school. Practices went from ending at 5 on regular days, to ending near 7; Gaining more skills. I’m now head-captain, going from strictly just basketball cheerleaders to full on hybrid team as competitors with competitions. There were many challenges I had to overcome this year. I, as a flyer, am learning to overcome that fear of going to a full extend and constantly falling and struggling to get to that check point, while also having to manage a team to keep going and never give up. There were so many times when my stunt just kept on tumbling down, “Okay lets take the stunt out you, girls aren’t ready” Coach would say as we kept restarting the stunt after multiple fails. We’d respond back and tell her “no we’re gonna get this” and went right back into the stunt with barely any breaks.

Me and my bases’ always communicated with each other wanting the same thing as a stunt group and as a team. A good stunt and a trophy to take home. They always made me feel

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safe and even when I did collapse on them, they always reassured me. “You’re fine, I’m fine, let's try again” at least one of them always said. I had to learn to get used to being lifted without me leaning too forward or sideways. I had to learn a corkscrew and spin mid air and still trust my bases to catch me. The more I fell, the better the next lift was. We saw our progress in live action and was so ecstatic the first time I went into a full extent without and fell. I got over my fear as they gained more and more strength to lift me up with ease.

Sitting on the mat as they actively play music in the background, crowds cheering for their schools and students, coaches with tense yet reassuring faces, and the cheer teams all holding hands anxiously. Here we are together, sitting together, being there for each other. Looking around, hoping to be placed in the top three, like any other team. We didn't care if we won or not, we just performed our best and pushed through with beating hearts, rapid breathing, and while overly heated. We did it! We made it to the finish line. While teams were being called to collect their trophies and medals. We made it to the first runner-up and we didn't get called. We didn't mind. We honestly didn't care. We were just happy to have the experience and the motivation that we gained through our hard work, challenging, overexemplifying, and exhausting cheer practices; we challenged ourselves and ended up in 4th place, only as a fresh competition team. Though we didn't leave with a trophy, we left with a medal in our hearts. Cheer taught me more than how to perform, it taught me confidence, teamwork, and how to believe in myself. I'm proud of the person I've become because of it.